

Learning by doing



One of the central notions of pragmatism as proposed by Peirce is that knowledge is not about facts, but valid explanations. In the same way as science provides adequate explanations that can be replaced with new or better ones, we acquire knowledge that gives us the information we need for action. The purpose of thinking and learning is to help us do things, and especially to survive in the world, not necessarily to give us an accurate picture of it. John Dewey, one of the next generation of American pragmatists, agreed with Peirce that we learn in order to survive, and that our knowledge comes from participating in, rather than observing, the

world we are trying to understand. This process is like a scientific method: we encounter a problem, analyse it and think of a possible solution, then test it through experiment. Either it works, and the problem is solved, or we have to think of another solution. In fact, we only think when we are confronted with problems, so the best way of acquiring knowledge is through being actively involved in tasks, and not by theorizing or rote learning.